



Megatooth shark

MEG-a-tooth shark



- **When** 25–1.5 million years ago (Late Paleogene to Early Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe, N. America, S. America, Africa, Asia
- **Habitat** Warm oceans
- **Length** 67 ft (20 m)

Only teeth and spine bones of the megatooth shark have been found. By comparing these with modern sharks, scientists estimate the megatooth shark may have weighed as much as 100 tonnes—as much as 30 elephants. Its fossil teeth are common in sites rich in sea mammals such as seals and dolphins, suggesting these were the megatooth's prey.

BIG TOOTH

Megatooth means “big tooth.” This shark certainly lived up to its name, with more than 250 teeth, each of which grew up to 7 in (17 cm) long. The teeth had sharp, serrated edges like the cutting side of a saw—ideal for slicing through flesh.



▲ **FOSSIL JAWS** of the megatooth shark have never been found, but scientists built the model above by scaling up a great white shark's jaws (in center). The megatooth's bite was five times more powerful than that of Tyrannosaurus—it could have crushed prey to death with a single bite.

